



10 Kinds of Sentences and Clauses

A group of words that contains a *subject* and a *predicate*, and makes complete sense by itself is a **sentence**.

A group of words that contains a *subject* and a *predicate*, and is part of a sentence is a **clause**.

The predicate must contain a finite verb, and it may consist of only a *finite verb*. We shall use the word *verb* to refer to a *finite verb*.



Kinds of Sentences

A sentence may contain one or more verbs, that is one or more than one clause.

1. Simple Sentences

(a) *The men were constructing a dam.*

(b) *Hardy is happy.*

Both sentences (a) and (b) contain only one clause each:

Subject: *men* | Predicate: *were constructing a dam* (verb—*were constructing*)

Subject: *Hardy* | Predicate: *is happy* (verb—*is*)

A sentence which contains only one clause is known as a **simple sentence**.

2. Complex Sentences

A sentence may contain more than one clause:

(c) *The girls sang a song that everybody liked.*

Sentence (c) contains two verbs: *sang, liked*. It, therefore, contains two clauses:

(i) Subject: *girls* | Predicate: sang a song (verb—*sang*)

(ii) Subject: *everybody* | Predicate: *that ...* liked (verb—*liked*)

Note that clause (i) makes complete sense by itself, but clause (ii) does not.

Clause (ii) tells us more about the noun *song* and depends on clause (i) to make sense.

We call clause (i) the **main** or **principal** clause.

We call clause (ii) a **dependent** or **subordinate** clause.

The word *dependent* means something which 'depends on' another thing.
The word *subordinate* means something which is 'of less importance' than another.

(d) *Hardy, who is Laurel's friend, is happy.*

This sentence contains two verbs—*is, is*—and so, contains two clauses:

(i) *Hardy is happy* | Subject: *Hardy* | Predicate: is happy

(ii) *who is Laurel's friend* | Subject: *who* | Predicate: is Laurel's friend

Clause (i) makes complete sense by itself, but clause (ii)—*who is Laurel's friend*—does not.

So, clause (i) is the **main** or **principal** clause and clause (ii) is a **dependent** or **subordinate** clause.

So, each of the sentences (c) and (d) contains *one* main clause and *one* subordinate clause.

Now look at this sentence:

(e) *Hardy, who is Laurel's friend, fell into a ditch, which was full of mud.*

This sentence contains three verbs: *is, fell, was*. So, it contains three clauses:

(i) *Hardy fell into a ditch* | Subject: *Hardy* | Predicate: fell into a ditch

(ii) *who is Laurel's friend* | Subject: *who* | Predicate: is Laurel's friend

(iii) *which was full of mud* | Subject: *which* | Predicate: was full of mud

Clause (i) makes complete sense by itself, but none of the clauses (ii) and (iii) makes complete sense by itself. So clause (i) is the **main/principal** clause, and clauses (ii) and (iii) are **subordinate clauses**.

Such a sentence, which consists of one main clause and one or more than one subordinate clause, is called a **complex sentence**.

3. Compound Sentences

A sentence, which contains two or more verbs, may contain two or more *main* or *principal* clauses:

(f) *Hardy is happy and Laurel is sad.*

This sentence contains two verbs—*is, is*—and so, contains two clauses:

(i) *Hardy is happy* Subject: *Hardy* | Predicate: *is happy*

(ii) *Laurel is sad* Subject: *Laurel* | Predicate: *is sad*

Each of the two clauses makes complete sense. They are joined together by the conjunction *and*.

Such clauses, which are parts of the same sentence and each of which makes complete sense by itself, are known as **coordinate** clauses.

The word *coordinate* means 'equal in importance or rank'.

(g) *Bread is good, but cake is better.*

This sentence contains two verbs—*is, is*—and so contains two clauses:

(i) *Bread is good* Subject: *bread* | Predicate: *is good*

(ii) *cake is better* Subject: *cake* | Predicate: *is better* ('*than bread*' is understood)

Each clause makes complete sense by itself. They are, therefore, coordinate clauses. They are joined together by the conjunction *but*.

(h) *One of the bird's wings was broken and it could not fly, and the little girl felt sad.*

This sentence contains three verbs—*was, could (not) fly, felt*—and so contains three clauses:

(i) *One of the bird's wings was broken*

Subject: *One of the bird's wings* | Predicate: *was broken*

(ii) *it could not fly*

Subject: *it* | Predicate: *could not fly*

(iii) *the little girl felt sad*

Subject: *(the little) girl* | Predicate: *felt sad*

The clauses are joined by the conjunction *and*. Each clause makes complete sense by itself. So all three are coordinate clauses.



Such a sentence, which contains two or more coordinate clauses, is known as a **compound sentence**.

Some call a compound sentence, consisting of two coordinate clauses, a *double sentence* and a compound sentence consisting of more than two coordinate clauses, a *multiple sentence*.

Compound Sentence: (Delhi is the capital of India)¹ and (London is the capital of England)².
(Double)

Compound Sentence: (Delhi is the capital of India)¹ and (London is the capital of England)², but (they are not as big as New York)³.
(Multiple)

4. Compound-Complex Sentences

A sentence may contain two or more coordinate clauses and one or more than one subordinate clause:

(i) *Arka, who is my friend, lives in Kolkata, and Ram, who is also a friend of mine, lives in Mumbai.*

The sentence consists of four clauses:

- | | |
|--|--|
| (i) <i>Arka <u>lives</u> in Kolkata</i> | Subject: <i>Arka</i> Predicate: <i><u>lives</u> in Kolkata</i> |
| (ii) <i>who <u>is</u> my friend</i> | Subject: <i>who</i> Predicate: <i><u>is</u> my friend</i> |
| (iii) <i>Ram <u>lives</u> in Mumbai</i> | Subject: <i>Ram</i> Predicate: <i><u>lives</u> in Mumbai</i> |
| (iv) <i>who <u>is</u> also my friend</i> | Subject: <i>who</i> Predicate: <i><u>is</u> also my friend</i> |

Each of the clauses (i) and (iii) makes complete sense by itself, but none of the clauses (ii) and (iv) makes complete sense by itself. So, clauses (i) and (iii) are coordinate clauses, and clauses (ii) and (iv) are subordinate clauses.

The two coordinate clauses are joined by the conjunction *and*.

A sentence which consists of two or more coordinate clauses and one or more than one subordinate clause is called a **compound-complex sentence**.

5. Complex Sentences with two or more subordinate clauses coordinate to one another

A complex sentence may contain two or more subordinate clauses coordinate to one another:

(j) *Rita lost the handbag, which Dipa had given her and in which she kept all her jewellery.*

There are three verbs in the sentence: *lost, had given, kept*.

So, the sentence contains three clauses:

- | | |
|---|---|
| (i) Rita <u>lost</u> the handbag | Subject: Rita Predicate: <u>lost</u> the handbag |
| (ii) which Dipa <u>had given</u> her | Subject: Dipa Predicate: which ... <u>had given</u> her |
| (iii) in which she <u>kept</u> all
her jewellery | Subject: she Predicate: in which ... <u>kept</u> all
her jewellery |

Clause (i)—*Rita lost the handbag*—is the main clause.

Clauses (ii) and (iii), which describe the noun *handbag*, are subordinate clauses. They are also coordinate to each other and joined together by the conjunction *and*.

So, the sentence as a whole is a complex sentence, because it contains one main clause and two subordinate clauses.

It is not a compound sentence, because the coordinate clauses are subordinate clauses and none of them makes complete sense by itself.

Such a sentence may, at best, be called a *complex-compound sentence*, but never a compound sentence. Always remember that a compound sentence must contain at least two main clauses which are coordinate to each other.



Kinds of Subordinate Clauses

We shall now look at three kinds of subordinate clauses:

1. Adjective Clauses
2. Adverb Clauses
3. Noun Clauses

1. Adjective Clauses

A clause which does the work of an adjective is an **adjective clause**.

(k) The boy, who had rescued the child from the fire, was rewarded for his bravery.

(l) Harsh, who is an intelligent boy, solved the problem easily.

In (k), the main clause is *The boy was rewarded for his bravery*, and *who had rescued the child from the fire* is a subordinate clause, for it does not make complete sense by itself.

(Subject: *who* | Predicate: had rescued the child from the fire)

It qualifies the noun *boy*, in the main clause. It is, therefore, a subordinate adjective clause.

Similarly, in (l), *who is an intelligent boy* is a subordinate adjective clause.

(Subject: *who* | Predicate: is an intelligent boy)

It qualifies the noun *Harsh* in the main clause: *Harsh solved the problem easily*.

A Pick out the **adjective clauses** from the following sentences. Also, mention the **nouns** they qualify:

1. Alexander, who conquered many countries, was a Macedonian.
2. This building, which was formerly a palace, has now become a museum.
3. The people saw the snake sliding into a hole that a rat had made in the floor.
4. The ships, which sank in the storm, belonged to a rich merchant.
5. The robbers hid in a cave which was high up in the mountains.
6. The crowd that had gathered to watch the race, cheered as the runners entered the stadium.
7. Did you see the film that won the first prize?
8. Many writers, who were great and famous, did not receive the Nobel Prize.
9. Who is that boy who is sitting all alone on the last bench?
10. Never trust a man who always speaks ill of others.

2. Adverb Clauses

A clause which does the work of an adverb is an **adverb clause**.

(m) *The ring was found where the thief had hidden the stolen jewellery.*

(n) *We reached the theatre after the play had started.*

In (m), *where the thief had hidden the stolen jewellery* is a clause.

[Subject: (the) thief | Predicate: *where ... had hidden the stolen jewellery*]

It, however, does not make complete sense by itself. So, it is a subordinate clause. Since it tells us where *The ring was found* (main clause), it is a subordinate adverb clause of place.

Similarly, in (n), *after the play had started* is a subordinate clause.

(Subject: *the play* | Predicate: *after ... had started*)

It tells us more about the time when we *reached* the theatre.

It is, therefore, a subordinate adverb clause of time.

So also, we can have adverb clauses of *reason* or *cause*, *purpose*, *condition*, *concession*, *result* and *comparison*.

(o) We were hungry because we had not eaten anything all day. (reason)

(p) The boy crept under the bed so that he might not be seen. (purpose)

(q) I will listen to you if you tell the truth. (condition)

(r) Although I do not trust him, I will lend him my camera. (concession)

(s) John had run so hard that he was out of breath. (result or effect)

(t) A true Roman loves honour more than he loves his own life. (comparison)

B Pick out the **adverb clauses** from the following sentences:

1. When his father Philip II of Macedon was murdered, Alexander became the king.
2. He ran as fast as he could.
3. The pirates buried their treasure where nobody would be able to find it.
4. The musicians started playing after the bride entered the room.
5. A friend, who helps you when you are in need, is a true friend.
6. The people had gathered in the marketplace as they had nowhere else to go.
7. You must explain the poem to me because it is very difficult.
8. If you want to get well, you must take this medicine as soon as possible.
9. The storm was so severe that the roofs of many houses were blown away.
10. When he comes, tell him that I could not wait for him any longer.

3. Noun Clauses

A clause which does the work of a noun is a **noun clause**.

Only a noun or a word or group of words that does the work of a noun can be the subject or object of a verb. Remember that a noun can be the object of a preposition also.

(u) What the captain had decided was accepted by all the players.

What the captain had decided is a clause that does not make complete sense by itself. It is, therefore, a subordinate clause.

(Subject: *(the) captain* | Predicate: *What ... had decided*)

It is the subject of the verb *was accepted* in the main clause.

(Q: *What* was accepted by all the players?

A: *What the captain had decided*)

So, it is a subordinate noun clause, subject of the verb *was accepted*.

Note that the main clause is: (Subject) + *was accepted by all the players*.

(v) *Nobody knows what caused the accident*.

In (v), *what caused the accident* is a subordinate clause.

(Subject: *what* | Predicate: *caused the accident*)

It is the object of the verb *knows*.

(Q: Nobody knows *what*? Ans: *what caused the accident*)

It is, therefore, a subordinate noun clause, object of the verb *knows* in the main clause.

The main clause is: *Nobody knows* + (object)



C Pick out the **noun clauses** from the following sentences:

1. What the people saw that night frightened them terribly.
2. The boy told his mother that he had not been up to any mischief at all.
3. Everybody believed that the sun went round the earth. Copernicus proved that the earth went round the sun.
4. Galileo recorded what he had observed in a book.

5. All that Mother had cooked had been eaten up by the dog.
6. The old man was telling us how useful things can be made out of discarded objects like empty bottles and tins.
7. Few people know what they really want.
8. The law will punish whoever is proved to be guilty.
9. Whatever their teacher told them in the class was noted down by the students.
10. The story narrated by Jesus described how a Samaritan had helped a man in distress.



D Pick out all the *clauses* from the following sentences and mention of *what kind each is*:

1. We told him what we had heard yesterday.
2. If you want to get into a good college, you must do well in your final examination.
3. Although he was severely wounded, the soldier did not leave his post.
4. After the bell rang, the pupils returned to their classrooms.
5. The people, who live next door, are very friendly.
6. Let us go and see the place where the battle took place.
7. Why has Joseph not come home though he knows his sister is ill?
8. Please do not disturb him when he is doing his homework.
9. All great religious teachers have told us that we must be truthful.
10. The play, which we staged, was liked by all.
11. Everybody was happy because everybody had received a gift.
12. He ate his dinner as fast as he could, for he had a train to catch.
13. Can you tell me when this shop usually opens?
14. The letter that I had kept on the table is missing.
15. Please come as soon as you can.

